ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Peer Pressure and Social Life: Keep Your Friends, Keep Your Standards

Make your own decisions about money, alcohol, relationships and belonging

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Freshers face new freedoms and new pressure at the same time. This pack explains how group influence works, gives scripts for refusing without drama, and helps you build friendships that support rather than undermine your goals.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain how conformity and social influence affect decisions.
- Recognise pressure around money, alcohol, cultism and relationships.
- Use clear, low-conflict refusal scripts.
- Build a social circle that supports your academic and personal goals.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why pressure works

Humans are wired to avoid exclusion, and that wiring can override judgement.

- We look to others when unsure, especially in a new environment.
- We conform to avoid standing out or being rejected.
- Small requests escalate; agreeing once makes agreeing again easier.
- Groups create shared stories about what is normal.
- Being tired, lonely or financially stretched increases susceptibility.
- Naming the pressure reduces its power.

Know your lines

Decide your standards before the moment and rehearse simple refusals.

- Direct: 'No, I am not doing that.'
- Redirect: 'I am not drinking, but I will still come for the music.'
- Delay: 'I need to think about it; I will get back to you.'
- Exit: 'I have to go now.'
- Broken record: repeat the same short answer without justifying.
- Refuse cultism and criminal groups absolutely; there is no safe level of involvement.

> **Say no to money pressure**
> Never borrow to match someone else's spending. A friend who mocks your budget is describing their values, not your worth.

Build good friendships

The strongest protection against bad influence is a small group with shared standards.

- Choose friends you would be comfortable introducing to your parents.
- Look for consistency between what people say and do.
- Keep at least one friend who will tell you the truth.
- Invest in people who celebrate your progress rather than compete with it.
- Keep contact with family or a mentor outside campus.
- Ask for help early if you feel trapped or threatened.

Pressure is usually ordinary

Peer pressure is rarely a dramatic dare. It is the accumulated expectation of a group: what everyone wears, where everyone goes on Friday, what nobody admits to finding difficult. Most of it is harmless, and some of it is genuinely valuable - friends who insist you attend lectures are applying pressure in your interest.

The pressure that causes damage is usually about three things: money, substances and risk. Spending to keep up, drinking to belong, and joining activities whose consequences you have not considered. The pattern is always the same - a short-term social gain traded against a longer-term cost.

Notice which groups make you more yourself and which make you perform. That distinction is a better guide than any rule about who to avoid.

Refusing without a scene

Most people fear refusal because they expect it to be humiliating. In practice, a calm, brief refusal delivered without a lecture ends the matter almost every time. The mistake is over-explaining, which invites negotiation.

Useful forms: "Not tonight." "I am not drinking." "I cannot afford it this month." "I have a test tomorrow." Each is complete. You do not owe an argument, and a friend who requires one is telling you something about the friendship.

Have an exit plan before you need one: your own transport money, a friend who will leave with you, and a code message to someone outside the situation. Planning an exit is not pessimism; it is the same logic as knowing where the fire exit is.

> **Decide in advance**
> Decisions made in the moment are made under social pressure. Decide your limits - money, alcohol, time - before you go out, when you are still the only person influencing you.

Friendship, conflict and loneliness

Good friendships are reciprocal and low-drama. If a relationship requires constant management, secrecy from other friends, or regular financial extraction, it is not a friendship with a problem - it is the problem.

Conflict is normal and manageable: describe the behaviour, state the effect, ask for a change, and be specific. "When you cancel at the last minute, I waste the transport fare and the afternoon" invites a response in a way that "you are unreliable" does not.

Loneliness in first year is extremely common and rarely discussed. It usually eases with repeated low-stakes contact - the same study group, the same society, the same church or mosque - rather than with effortful attempts to make a best friend immediately. If it persists and affects sleep, appetite or study, the counselling service exists for exactly that.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Refusing an expensive outing

Your group plans a trip that costs more than your monthly allowance.

1. Decide before the conversation: you are not going.
2. Give one short reason without apology: "I cannot afford it this month."
3. Do not offer to borrow or to pay later.
4. Suggest an alternative you can afford, if you want to stay involved.
5. If pressed, repeat the same sentence rather than adding new reasons.
6. Follow up with the group afterwards so the refusal does not end the friendship.

> **What to carry forward**
> One sentence, repeated. Every added reason is an invitation to negotiate.

2. Raising a problem with a housemate

A friend repeatedly borrows money and does not repay.

1. Choose a private moment, not a group setting.
2. State the facts: two loans, dates and amounts.
3. State the effect: you now cannot cover your own transport.
4. Ask for a specific action: repayment by a date, or an agreement to stop borrowing.
5. Agree what happens next if it repeats.
6. Do not lend again on the basis of a promise alone.

> **What to carry forward**
> Facts, effect, request, agreement. Emotion is legitimate but should not replace the specific ask.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish positive from negative peer influence with examples.

10 marks

1. Positive: encouragement towards study, health, responsibility.
2. Negative: pressure towards spending, substances, risk.
3. Explain that the mechanism is the same - group expectation - and the outcome differs.

Q2. Describe an effective strategy for refusing pressure without confrontation.

10 marks

1. Decide in advance.
2. Give one brief reason and repeat it.
3. Avoid over-explaining.
4. Have an exit plan.
5. Maintain the relationship afterwards.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Peer pressure. Influence from a group to conform to its expectations.

Social conformity. Changing behaviour to match a group's norms.

Assertiveness. Stating your position clearly without aggression or apology.

Exit plan. A prepared way to leave a situation safely.

Reciprocity. Mutual give and take in a relationship.

Boundary. A stated limit on what you will accept or do.

Loneliness. Distress from perceived lack of connection, distinct from being alone.

Counselling service. Confidential support provided by the institution.

Financial peer pressure. Spending to maintain social standing.

Code message. A prearranged signal asking a friend to help you leave.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Notice

Patterns.

- Identify three situations where you spend to fit in.
- Note which groups energise you.
- Write your limits in advance.

Week 2 - Practise

Refusal.

- Rehearse three short refusals aloud.
- Use one in a real situation.
- Notice that the conversation ends.

Week 3 - Connect

Belonging.

- Attend one group twice.
- Initiate one low-stakes conversation.
- Plan a cheap shared activity.

Week 4 - Repair

Conflict.

- Raise one small issue using facts and request.
- Ask for one change.
- Know the counselling contact.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A student wellbeing guide covering social pressure and boundaries.
- Your institution's counselling service information.
- A communication guide on assertive requests.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why does conformity increase in new environments?

Answer: Uncertainty makes people rely on others for cues about acceptable behaviour, and the need to belong is strong.

2. Give two refusal scripts.

Answer: 'No, I am not doing that' and 'I need to think about it; I will get back to you.'

3. Why is a broken-record refusal effective?

Answer: It gives no new argument to negotiate against and signals a settled decision.

4. What should you do if a friend is pressuring you financially?

Answer: State your limit clearly, decline, and reconsider how much time you spend with someone who disregards it.

5. Why is cultism a hard no rather than a risk to manage?

Answer: Involvement is criminal, violent and difficult to exit; there is no safe level of participation.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your personal non-negotiables in three lines.
- [ ] Rehearse two refusal lines aloud.
- [ ] Identify one friend who supports your goals.
- [ ] Set a weekly social budget and stick to it.
- [ ] Know the support contacts for counselling or security.
- [ ] Leave any group that repeatedly ignores your boundaries.
- [ ] Check in on a coursemate who seems isolated.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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